SWEN303 ASSIGNMENT 3 INTERVIEW Q&A

Cara: Student studying a BSc majoring in Computer science and Earth Science

Q: Tell me about a group project you worked on previously (or this one), what was it for, and how big was the group?
A: I had a group project recently which had 5 or 6 people. The project was pretty cool, we were making a game in Godot.

Q: Walk me through how your group first got organised, what tools did your group decide to use, who decided what gets used, and why did you choose them?
A: We used Discord, similar to what we're doing in SWEN. We made our own group. We did use Gitlab but we also used a Miro board, which is similar to Trello if you've heard of that.

Q: How much of the tools you use are provided by the university(GitLab, Canvas) versus externally (Discord, Google Docs, GitHub etc)?
A: The only tool that we used which was actually provided by the university was GitLab. Most of the workflow and organization related things were done externally.

Q: Tell me about the last time your group needed to share or edit a document together. What did you actually use, and how did that go? Was it convenient?
A: The last thing we had to edit together was a readme, but with the tools we were using it was fine and there were not really any conflicts.

Q: How did you group manage to keep track of who was doing what?
A: So we did use GitLab issues, which we assigned to people. But in order to figure out who was doing what, we communicated more on Discord rather than GitLab itself.

Q: Tell me about a time group coordination went badly. What happened, and how did it make you feel?

A:

There was one person that didn't do any work and just went AWOL. We found out because they hadn't committed anything, and didn't respond when we tried to contact them. Halfway through they asked us to show them how to get the project on their computer.

I know that we could have complained but we weren't thinking about it at the time, and were just focused on picking up the slack. All he did was come to a few in-person meetings without contributing.

It's also frustrating when you organize a meeting and people don't show up and don't give alternative time to have the meeting. It feels like they just want to coast and not contribute.

Q: Has there been a time a tool(s) you were using (Git, Docs, Discord, whatever) got in the way rather than helped. What happened?

A:
Last year GitLab just stopped working because of people from other courses submitting

Q:
Last year when we were doing our group project, everyone was making git requests on the last day, which caused the servers to completely stop working. Nobody could even load anything, and they had to give us an extension.

Q: Has the amount of external tools required for a project ever felt inconvenient or overwhelming? How so, and what did you do to manage?

A:

I don't like vero, but nothing has felt overwhelming.

Q: Would you prefer if there were less degrees of separation between the platforms?

If they were integrated that would be convenient. Gitlab sort of tried to do this, but it's just not there. It's not like Discord where instant communication is seamless. It has its specific things that it's good at, but for most communication applications you are going to use other platforms.

Q: Was there a moment you felt out of the loop on what your group had done? Tell me about it.
A: No it is easy to stay on top of it when you have a Discord group.

Q: Is there a habit your group settled into for staying coordinated (e.g. weekly in person meeting, Discord server)?
A: We had weekly in person meetings and kept each other informed via discord.

Q: Tell me about the last time your group submitted a project. Walk me through that process, step by step. Was it as convenient as a one-button submission or did you have to round up files from different external sources (Google Docs, GitHub, IntelliJ)?
A: The last time was on GitLab. Actually, I had to make a video demonstrating the project, but I uploaded that to youtube and pasted the URL into GitLab. Other than that, everything else was on GitLab which was fine. I didn’t really have to round up anything else because it was all already there.

Q: Did your group ever get stuck and need help (i.e from a tutor or lecturer)? What did you do?
A: No, not really.

Q: How did that compare to how you'd ask for help on solo work?
A: For solo work I normally send an email to the professor, or go to the helpdesk. It would be cool if there was a way to get help within the system.

Q: As a whole, would you say you're satisfied with the way group projects are ran through uni?
A: I have a few issues. Finding and creating your group is different for every group project I have done. Everything was difficult until we had the Discord set up and everybody was in it. For this project it was hard to even find the group page, let alone find the group members and their information. It feels like nothing is consistent, and the current tools barely do what they're supposed to while making it as complicated as possible.

Q: Is there anything about working in groups at uni that's been a problem that you haven't mentioned yet?
A: I think we've covered everything.